Nicholas Kashani Motlagh

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Education

Ohio State University — Columbus, OH
Ph.D. in Computer Science and Engineering — Aug 2021 – Aug 2026
Dissertation: *Answering Under Uncertainty: Abstention, Ambiguity, and Recoverability* (defended July 8, 2026)
M.S. in Computer Science and Engineering — Aug 2021 – May 2025
Advisor: Prof. Jim Davis; Minors: Mathematics and High-Performance Computing — GPA: 3.70

Ohio State University — Columbus, OH
B.S. in Computer Science and Engineering with Honors — Aug 2017 – May 2021
Minor: Mathematics; Scholarships: Maximus, Ten-Hai Lai, Ansel, Name and Seal — GPA: 3.86

Experience

Graduate Research Associate, Computer Vision Lab — Aug 2021 – Present
Ohio State University, Columbus, OH
- **Retrieval-Augmented Selective QA** (under review at ACL Rolling Review, 2026; title withheld): modeled paired direct/refined outcomes on 25,870 held-out questions to evaluate answer, refine, or abstain policies.
- **Assessing the Role of Imagery in Multimodal Machine Translation** (WMT 2024): introduced ImageCoMMuTE metrics separating visual understanding from final translation decisions.
- **Naturally Constrained Reject Option Classification** (MVA 2025): developed Binomial-CDF reject-option constraints with per-class thresholds across synthetic, image, and text datasets.
- **Learning When to Say "I Don't Know"** (ISVC 2022, Springer Best Paper Award): learned per-class softmax thresholds for abstention without user-defined rejection costs.

Graduate Teaching Associate / Course Grader, Ohio State University — Aug 2023 – Dec 2025
- Served as GTA through May 2025; graded machine learning and NLP coursework and led Excel-based computing labs.

Technical Analyst II — May 2025 – Present
DCS Corporation / Air Force Research Laboratory, Dayton, OH
- Trained and evaluated LLMs with reject-option capabilities for analyst-facing evaluation.

Graduate Research Intern — Summers 2022–2024
Air Force Research Laboratory, Dayton, OH
- Summer 2024: Adapted JEPA and MAE transformers for multimodal EO/SAR representation learning in low-data regimes.
- Summer 2023: Developed Reject Option Beam Search to improve machine translation quality at large beam widths.
- Summer 2022: Built the end-to-end training procedure for Naturally Constrained Reject Option Classification.

Undergraduate Research Intern, Air Force Research Laboratory — Summers 2020–2021
- **Temporal Satellite Imagery** (ICCV Workshop 2021): built an OpenStreetMap-guided Python pipeline for remote-sensing change detection and classification datasets.

Selected Publications and Manuscripts

[1] **N. Kashani Motlagh** et al. Manuscript under review on retrieval-augmented selective QA (title withheld during double-blind review), 2026.
[2] **N. Kashani Motlagh** et al. "Naturally Constrained Reject Option Classification." *Machine Vision and Applications* 36, Article 9, 2025.
[3] **N. Kashani Motlagh** et al. "Assessing the Role of Imagery in Multimodal Machine Translation." *WMT*, pp. 1428–1439, 2024.
[4] **N. Kashani Motlagh** et al. "Learning When to Say 'I Don't Know'." *ISVC*, pp. 196–210, 2022. Springer Best Paper Award.
[5] **N. Kashani Motlagh** et al. "A Framework for Semi-automatic Collection of Temporal Satellite Imagery for Analysis of Dynamic Regions." *ICCV Workshop*, pp. 704–712, 2021.

Technical Skills

Languages and Tools: Python, PyTorch, vision-language models, Hugging Face, Git, Slurm, Singularity, LaTeX

Professional Service

Reviewer: ICCV 2023, CVPR 2023, ECCV 2022, CVPR 2022 **Volunteer:** HackOHI/O 2023